cultivated with toddy trees, also had stone quarries that were later used for ballasting the railway line. As quarrying would destroy plantations, it was necessary for the railways to have absolute rights over the land to make radical changes in land use. The GIPR bought the land at a cost of ₹4,000. Phipps' land, with the engine in it, was the city's new attraction and it drew crowds from all parts of town, the site resembling a fair.

ER…WHAT TO CALL IT?

Some Indians, who had, by that time, seen a working steamship, started calling the rail engine an aag boat (a steamer), or sometimes an agni rath (a fire chariot), due to the striking similarities of smoke, soot and whistle with it. Interestingly, it was the English newspapers of the day that were at a loss for words. They debated in their periodicals on what to call the locomotive in the local language—a steam ship, a steam chariot or something more convincing.

> By what name is a railway locomotive to be known among the natives? This is not an utterly uninteresting question. They have already commenced to call her 'aag boat', which is the name given by them to a steam vessel; but this is absurd. It is suggested that the proper appellation would be 'bauf ka rutthee' [*sic*], which means a steam chariot. Now is the time to settle this important matter. If the term 'aag boat' is allowed to prevail at this time, it will infallibly stick. [42]

The debate continued. Meanwhile, the 'fair' at Byculla grounds to see the locomotive in action also attracted the attention of newspapers. The *Bombay Telegraph* dated 17 February 1852 reported:

> The native population appear to evince great interest in the 'fire chariot' as they name her, and crowd round to have a look. The weight and massive character of the whole is quite at variance with their notion of speed; and, after observing the slow progress she made when being dragged along the public road by 200 coolies, their incredulous look of astonishment is not to be wondered at, when told, that in a few days she will be able to pass the race course swifter than their fleetest Arabs. [43]

The first locomotive in action gave the native population a cultural shock. The locals, unaware of the industrial developments taking place on the other side of the world, were confident that the mechanical contraption of a running, smoke-belching steam machine pulling wagons was an all-powerful mystical creature. It gave rise to strange ideas and stranger rumours. They were confident that the monster would soon spread its ill effects on society.